Elena, ACME’s CEO, leaned forward slightly as Ravi, the company’s CIO, finished his update. “Before we move on,” she said, “I’d like Sam, our CISO, to walk us through how we’re managing risk as more decisions move out of human workflows and into automated systems.”

Sam nodded. A year earlier, the request might have been framed very differently, as a security review or a compliance check. Now the board expected a broader answer. “What’s changed,” Sam began, “is that we no longer treat authorization as something embedded in individual systems. Decisions about who or what can act are evaluated consistently, using shared policies and real-time signals. That gives us visibility we simply didn’t have before.”

One board member frowned slightly. “Visibility is good,” he said, “but does it mean we’re taking on more risk? You’re delegating more authority to partners and software agents. Isn’t that inherently dangerous?”

Sam glanced briefly at Ravi before answering. “We are taking on more responsibility,” he said. “But the risk is bounded. Delegation is explicit now. Every decision is constrained by policy. We can see how authority flows across teams, across customers, even across systems. That allows us to take risks intentionally rather than discovering them after the fact.”

Ravi picked up the thread. “From the platform side,” he said, “this has been transformative. We used to spend enormous effort trying to make access decisions consistent across services. Each product team solved the problem differently. That slowed delivery and created unpredictable behavior for customers. Now decision logic is externalized. Teams build against shared policy infrastructure. We move faster because the rules are clear.”

Another board member leaned forward. “So you’re saying this is both a security improvement and an operational improvement?”

“It’s more than that,” Ravi replied. “It’s architectural. We’ve effectively built a decision layer for the company. Whether an employee shares a document, a partner invokes an API, or an agent executes a workflow, the question of authorization is answered using the same policy framework. That consistency lets us scale.”